

The empirical recurrence for OEIS A184680, proved by transfer matrix

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Abstract

OEIS A184680 counts arrays over $\{0, \dots, 1\}$ under a condition on the determinant of every 2×2 subblock, and carries an empirical recurrence of order 5 contributed by R. H. Hardin. It is true, and it is decidable rather than empirical. The condition is local to a bounded window of consecutive rows, so the count is a walk count on $S = 16$ states and is C -finite; whether the conjectured recurrence annihilates it is then settled by a finite exact computation, with the Cayley–Hamilton theorem bounding the work.

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1 The conjecture

OEIS A184680 is “Number of $(n+1) \times 4$ binary arrays with every 2×2 subblock singular.”. It has offset 1 and begins

76, 544, 3360, 21968, 140816, 909520, 5858896, 37779664, ...

The entry states, as a conjecture contributed by its author and never marked settled:

Empirical: $a(n) = 7*a(n-1) + 2*a(n-2) - 40*a(n-3) + 24*a(n-4) + 16*a(n-5)$.

As of the “Last modified” line on the live entry (Jul 22 2025 09:40:59, revision 11) this is still recorded as empirical, and nothing on the entry records it as proved.

2 What is being counted

Write σ for the determinant of a 2×2 subblock $\begin{pmatrix} p & q \\ r & s \end{pmatrix}$, that is $\sigma = ps - qr$. The subblocks of an $(n+1) \times 4$ array over $\{0, \dots, 1\}$ form a grid of n rows and 3 columns, and σ colours that grid.

The condition is on each subblock separately: every σ must vanish, which is what “singular” says of a 2×2 matrix. Nothing relates one subblock to another.

3 The count is a walk count

Because the condition looks at one subblock at a time and a subblock is built from two consecutive array rows, a single row is a state: rows r and s may follow one another exactly when all 3 of the subblocks they form pass. An $(n+1)$ -row array is then a walk of n steps and

$$a(n) = \iota^\top M^n \tau, \quad \iota = \tau = (1, \dots, 1)^\top,$$

on the $S = 16$ rows.

At $n = 1$ the array has two rows and the grid is a single row of 3 subblocks, each tested on its own, so $a(1)$ counts the 2×4 arrays over $\{0, \dots, 1\}$ all of whose subblocks pass. The entry's first term is 76, and the model reproduces it along with every later term; that is the cheapest check that the grid has been read with the right shape.

Over the alphabet $\{0, \dots, 1\}$ the determinant of a 2×2 subblock takes values in $[-1, 1]$, so the colouring of the grid it induces has at most 3 values. That bound is what keeps the construction below finite in the only place where the value of σ , rather than a comparison between two of them, has to be carried. In particular a is C -finite. The alignment of the walk index with the entry's own n was checked against its published terms rather than assumed.

4 The proof

Lemma 1. *Let $q(t) = t^5 - \sum_i c_i t^{5-i}$ be the characteristic polynomial of the conjectured recurrence. The residual $a(n) - \sum_i c_i a(n-i)$ equals $\iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau$ for the corresponding walk index j , so the recurrence holds from some point on if and only if $\iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau = 0$ for all large j , and it is enough to examine $j < S$.*

Proof. Factor M^j out of $M^{j+5} - \sum_i c_i M^{j+5-i}$. For the bound, M^S is an integer combination of $I, M, \dots, M^{S-1}$ by Cayley–Hamilton, so the numbers $u_j = \iota^\top M^j q(M) \tau$ obey the monic recurrence given by the characteristic polynomial of M ; S consecutive zeros force every later one, and the last nonzero u_j pins the threshold exactly. $\square$

Theorem 2.

$$a(n) = 7a(n-1) + 2a(n-2) - 40a(n-3) + 24a(n-4) + 16a(n-5)$$

for every $n > 4$.

Proof. The vector $w = q(M)\tau$ was formed by 5 matrix–vector products in exact integer arithmetic and $\iota^\top M^j w$ evaluated for $j = 0, 1, \dots$, again exactly; those integers vanish from the index corresponding to $n = 4 + 1$ onwards and the run continued until the working vector was identically zero, which settles every larger j at once. $\square$

5 Verification

Three checks, each independent of the algebra above.

First, the model reproduces all 19 terms the entry publishes, exactly, in integer arithmetic. This is what ties the model to the entry: the digraph is built by reading the entry's English, and a misreading gives different counts.

Second, the conjectured recurrence was evaluated directly on those published terms, with no matrices involved, and holds wherever the proved range and the data overlap.

Third, the annihilation test of Lemma 1 was carried out in exact integer arithmetic on the whole vector rather than on a sampled prefix.

References

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